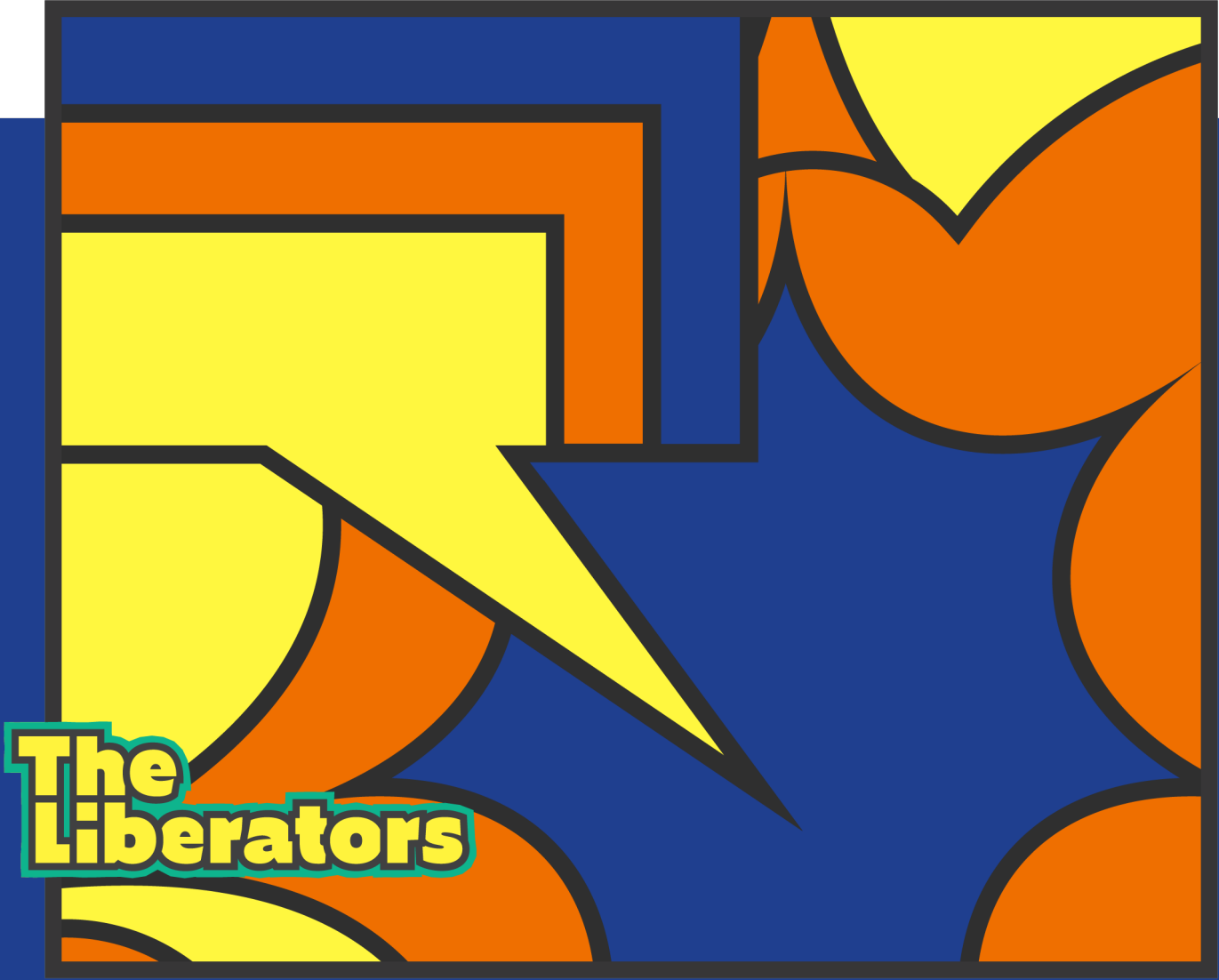


Make The Cost Of Low Autonomy Transparent With Permission Tokens

The simple experiment drives continuous learning and increases team autonomy by showing where a lack of autonomy is causing impediments

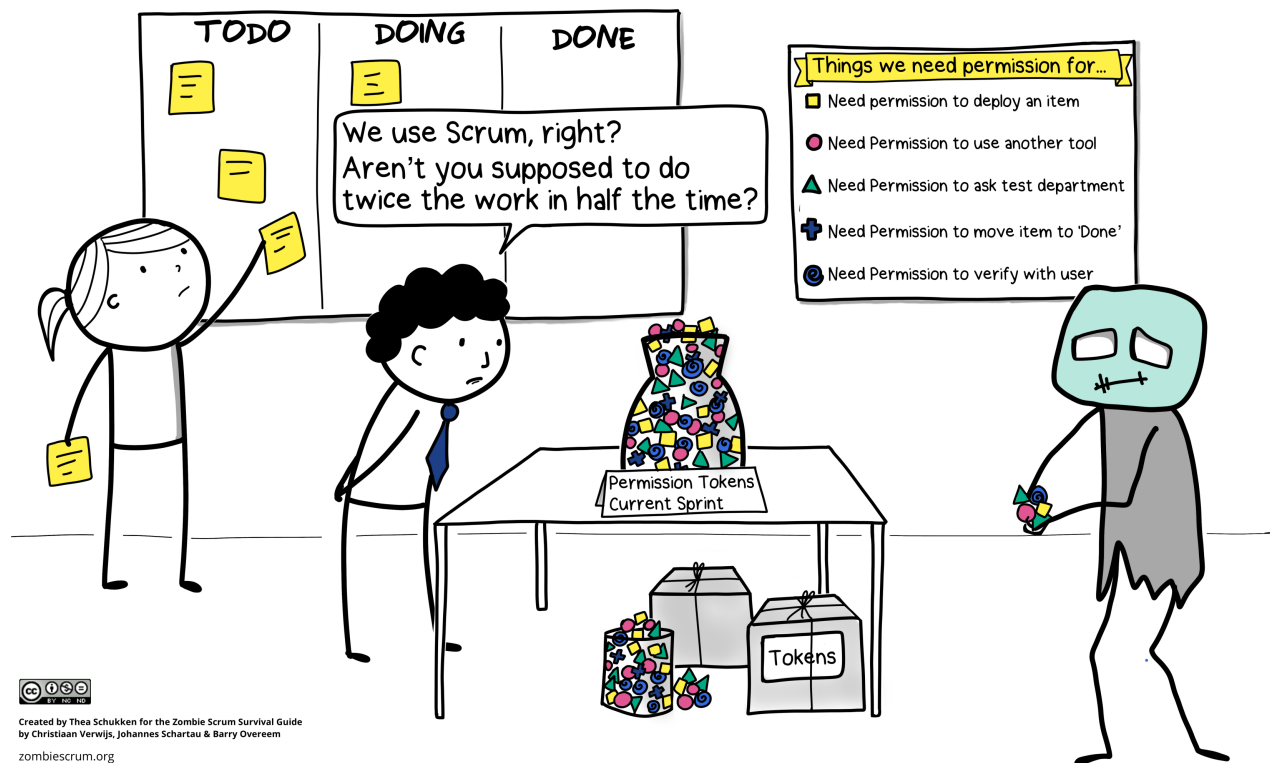


**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This Experiment

The autonomy of teams decreases as their dependencies on external people increase. Some dependencies are explicit, such as when a Scrum team needs someone outside the team to do something for them. Other dependencies are more implicit. Having to ask for permission or approval from someone outside the team in order to proceed is a good example.

This experiment is about making transparency where and how often permission is required.



Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment requires only a jar, some tokens, and a few minutes during your Sprint Review.

Impact On Survival



Even in the most zombie environments, regaining some sense of control makes people sigh with relief.

Steps



To try this experiment, do the following:

1. Find an empty jar, or another container, and place it in the team room. Somewhere near the Sprint Backlog is the best spot.
2. Give everyone on your team a bunch of permission tokens. You can use marbles, LEGO bricks, magnets, or stickies. Use different colors for the various permission categories. For example, the permission to release something, to move an item to another column on your Scrum Board, or to change your tools or environment. We recommend a limit of five categories to keep things simple.
3. During the Sprint, put an approval token in the jar every time someone on the Scrum team has to ask permission from someone outside the team. For example, put a token in the jar when an external architect needs to approve that an item is done. Or when the Product Owner has to vet an item with an external manager. Put a token in the jar when you need permission from office management to purchase stickies. And put a token in the jar when you need a configuration to be changed by an external administrator. Aside from requests for permission, also add a token every time you need someone outside the team to perform a specific action as well.
4. During the Sprint Review, and with stakeholders present, share the number of tokens in the jar. Ask: "How does this affect our ability to quickly adapt in the moment and do what is the most valuable? Where can we simplify things?" Invite people to first consider this question for themselves and in silence, then in pairs for two minutes, and then paired with another pair for four more minutes. Capture the most salient improvements with the whole group. The Sprint Retrospective is a great opportunity for digging into potential improvements.

Our Findings



- It can be tempting to identify dozens of potential improvements and end up doing nothing at all. Instead, keep a strong focus on improving one thing first before moving on to something else. If that improvement is too big to commit to doing it in a single Sprint, make it smaller;
- Make sure the entire Scrum team participates in the workshop. Not only the Product Owner and Scrum Master. Otherwise, it will quickly become a tool to assess the Development Team. This will not only damage trust but entirely misses the point of the survey.
- Frequently conduct the survey with the entire team. Don't do it once. Make it a recurring activity. This allows the team to learn what has changed over time, and what didn't. These are probably the more challenging things to change and might need a different approach.
- Ask other teams to do the survey as well. When the organization consists of multiple Scrum teams, invite them to fill in the survey as well. This allows you to discover patterns or things that are completely different. What is it that the teams have in common? What seems to be a challenge in the organization? So what should all the teams try to improve?



More Resources

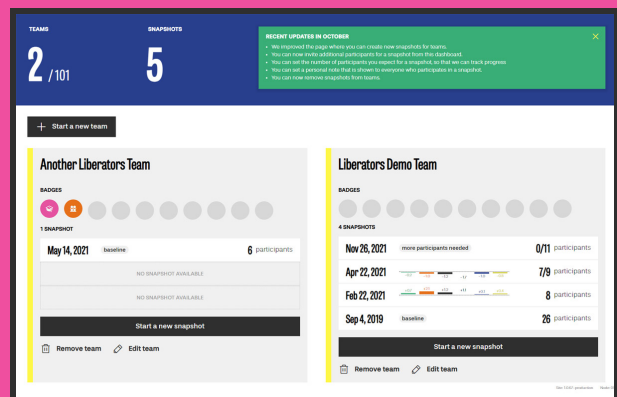
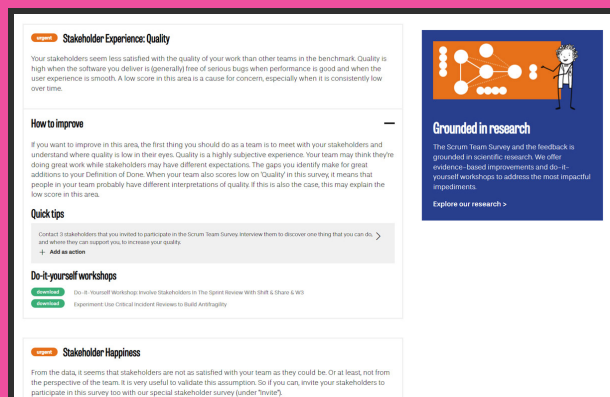
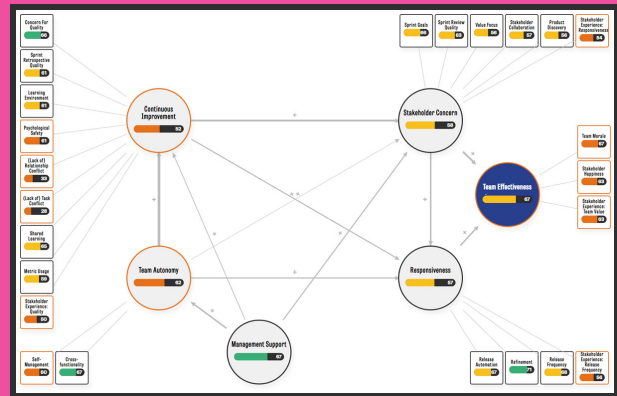
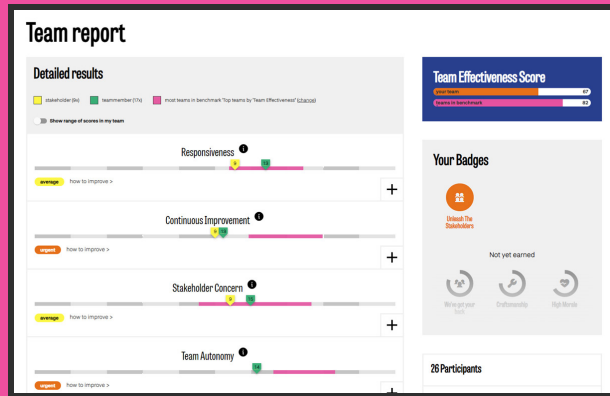


- Whitepaper: [The 8 Stances of a Scrum Master](#) illustrates well why Scrum Masters are responsible for removing certain impediments.
- Research: [How Do Scrum Masters Deal With Problems Outside Of Their Team's Control?](#). Together with [Age of Product](#), we asked Scrum Masters how they overcame impediments (including dependencies).
- Podcast: [Scrum Mythbusters: The Scrum Master Must Resolve Every Problem](#)



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Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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